to use TDD as a design tool. If you can check Twitter while your tests are running, you just aren't going to get the full value of the TDD process.

Tests get slow for a number of reasons, but the most important in a Rails context are as follows:

- Startup time
- Dependencies within the code that require a lot of objects to be created to invoke the method under test
- Extensive use of the database or other external services during a test

Not only do large object trees slow down the test at runtime, but setting up large amounts of data makes writing the tests more labor-intensive. And if writing the tests becomes burdensome, you aren't going to do it.

Speeding tests up often means isolating application logic from the Rails stack so that logic can be tested without loading the entire Rails stack or without retrieving test data from the database. As with a lot of good testing practices, this isolation results in more robust code that is easier to change moving forward.

Since test speed is so important for successful TDD, throughout the book I'll discuss ways to write fast tests. In particular, the discussion of creating data in Chapter 6, *Adding Data to Tests*, on page 101, and the discussion of testing environments in Chapter 16, *Running Tests Faster and Running Faster Tests*, on page 319, will be concerned with creating fast tests.

Truthful

A *truthful* test accurately reflects the underlying code—it passes when the underlying code works, and fails when it doesn't. This is easier said than done.

A frequent cause of brittle tests is targeting assertions at surface features that might change even if the underlying logic stays the same. The classic example along these lines is view testing, in which you base the assertion on the creative text on the page (which will frequently change even though the basic logic stays the same):

```
it "shows the project section" do
  get :dashboard
  expect(response).to have_selector("h2", :text => "My Projects")
end
```

It seems like a perfectly valid test right up until somebody determines that "My Projects" is a lame header and decides to go with "My Happy Fun-Time